Westbrook City Council

~ Regular Meeting ~

Date: Monday, January 5, 2026
Time: 6:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1151721884
Packet: https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_01052026-979

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Roll Call & President Pro Tem

Roll Call & Election of President Pro Tem [0:05]

Discussion Summary

First meeting of 2026. Roll call: Councilors Shaughnessy, McCambridge, Chau, Turcotte, Faulkingham, and Rairdon answered present — six of seven members (President Jennifer Munro was not named at roll call at all). In the President's and Vice President's absence (Shaughnessy did join and vote by Zoom but did not preside), the Council elected **Councilor Victor Chau as President Pro Tem** to run tonight's meeting.

Key Decisions

✓ Chau elected President Pro Tem by unanimous roll call.

Action Items

None.

Mayor's Message

New City Administrator, Budget Good News & County Fiscal Watch [2:22]

Discussion Summary

Mayor David Morse welcomed new City Administrator Angela Holmes to her first meeting in the role (sworn in the prior Friday).

Workers' compensation savings: the City's 2026 premium came in at $360,373, down sharply from $556,683 in 2025 — driven by the experience-modification rate improving from 1.08 to 0.84. The FY26 budget had set aside $645,000, so this is a large favorable variance heading into next year's budget.

Cumberland County fiscal watch: if the County's federal contract covering ICE detainees is terminated, the County budget would need to grow ~13.77% instead of ~5.37% — something to watch for the FY27 city budget.

Holiday tree pickup runs Dec. 29 – Jan. 12, with accommodation for residents observing Orthodox Christmas (Jan. 6–7).

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Trash Collection Crisis Over the Holidays [7:27]

Discussion Summary

A Dec. 23–24 snowstorm caused Casella Waste to cancel routes; because that week's collection was already shifted for Christmas, no makeup day was available. Casella told the City it would let residents drop off trash at its County Road facility all week — but when a resident tried to, staff at the gate turned him away, saying Westbrook wasn't part of their program. Director Eric Dudley made calls up the chain and drove to the transfer station himself to get it resolved. Missed streets continued into the following week, and the Wednesday, Dec. 31 route was so backed up that Casella brought employees in on their New Year's Day holiday to finish it.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken; ongoing issue.

Action Items

• Mayor has asked Eric Dudley to meet with Casella leadership and legal counsel to review the contract — Assignee: Administration | Deadline: none set.

> *"The folks at the gate were told to not accept Westbrook trash... which is not what they had offered us and certainly not what we relayed to the general public as well as all of you... I find [that] completely unacceptable."*

— Director of Engineering & Public Services Eric Dudley [7:27]

> *"I think that there — you cannot have a monopoly on a garbage [contract] that long... I think that we could be a little more creative in finding solutions to step away from that contract."*

— Councilor Anna Turcotte [15:40]

Dudley confirmed the City checked Waste Management as an alternative in 2020 but found it 30–40% more expensive, and isn't aware of any other automated curbside hauler currently operating in Maine. The City's relationship with Casella goes back 30+ years; the current 10-year contract began in 2025.

Council Messages & Student Representative

Council Messages & Student Representative Update [19:37]

Discussion Summary

Brief: Councilor Turcotte noted the meeting fell on Orthodox Christmas Eve for her household. No student representative messages at this time.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items
None.

Public Comment (First)

[20:04] Two kinds of public comment tonight: a resident previewing the Foster Street parking debate taken up later in New Business (see below), and four written letters read into the record on a separate, more sensitive matter.

Carson Wood (20 Foster St.)
A longtime resident who is now completely blind previewed his request for an accessible parking space positioned directly in front of his steps, not shifted toward Main Street as then drawn. See the full debate under Order 2026-01 below.

The Dory Schollberger / 12 Water Street Letters
Not discussed by the Council on the record — reproduced here because these are the public's own words on a contentious matter, not because any councilor or staff member responded to them tonight.

> *"Dory is a big part of this neighborhood... She has lived her whole life at this address... I am asking you to stop the eviction process and either sell her the land or give her a long-term rental."*

— Don Kelly, read by City Clerk Ellis Ledoux (on behalf of neighbor Don Kelly, for "Dory") [24:09]

> *"Your discussions have all been behind closed doors in executive session. There are no public records to indicate anything that is being discussed... Twelve Water Street has been a house lot for over sixty years. Why can it not continue as a house lot?"*

— Alice Peterson [24:09]

> *"I urge the city to sell Dory the plot of land upon which her house stands. If it does not, it should at least compensate her the fair market value of her house, as is done by taking an eminent domain."*

— Sarah Conley [24:09]

Conley cited a Zillow estimate of $75,000 for the house without land; city records list a $78,015 replacement cost. The meeting later entered executive session for "pending or contemplated litigation" with no further public detail — readers should not assume this is the same matter without confirmation, but the timing and subject overlap is worth noting.

Orders of the Day — Second & Final Reading

Orders 2025-169, 170, 171 — Consent Block (Non-Union Pay Plan, Police Lateral-Hire Reimbursement, Highway Safety Grant Funds) [28:04]

Discussion Summary
Moved together by title only: Order 2025-169, a non-union pay plan adjustment ($99,101.44, including a 4% COLA and grade corrections for 9 employees below market); Order 2025-170, a $48,671 reimbursement to the

City of South Portland for a lateral-hire officer's training costs (required by state law); and Order 2025-171, acceptance of $38,621.40 in Bureau of Highway Safety traffic-enforcement grant funds across six categories.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved as a block by unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

New Business

Liquor License — Town Line Diner [29:08]

Found on page 33 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Public hearing, no objections. Owner Joshua Gelston (who also owns Duck Pond Variety) introduced himself; councilors welcomed the reopening of the long-vacant former Pine Tree Bakery space at 1575 Bridgton Road.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Resolve 2026-01 — Annual Warden & Ward Clerk Appointments [33:11]

Discussion Summary

Amended on the floor to add Hillary Schmalke as a Ward Clerk for 2026, alongside the reappointment of Amanda Hollander as Warden and Jeremy Pelletier as Ward Clerk.

Key Decisions

✓ Amendment approved 6–0; full resolve approved 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Resolve 2026-02 — Zoning Board of Appeals & Planning Board Reappointments [36:24]

Discussion Summary

Confirms reappointment of Jason Frazier, Nancy Litrocapes, and John Turcott to the Planning Board, and Aaron Burns, Kevin Moss, and Sherri Quint to the Zoning Board of Appeals (plus Nancy Milton-Heath to a 2-year ZBA term as an administrative correction). **Councilor Anna Turcotte recused herself**, citing John Turcott's inclusion on the list (relationship not stated on the record).

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 6–0 with one abstention (Turcotte).

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-01 — Foster Street Parking

[39:33] One reading only. Amends the Code of Ordinances (§310-71, §310-106) to let the Police Chief and Director of Public Services designate — and later remove — accessible parking spaces on Foster Street as needs change, instead of hard-coding a specific location into the ordinance itself.

Carson Wood, a longtime 20 Foster St. resident who is now completely blind, asked for an accessible space directly in front of his steps so he can manage trash cans, groceries, and service vehicles without using street parking he otherwise never relies on.

> *"What it needs to be starting at is at the end of [the porch post]... where I need a handicap spot is right in front of my steps... I don't need it up the street or down the street."*

— Carson Wood (public comment) [1:00:03]

The amendment attempt — Councilor Gary Rairdon

> *"I would like to make an amendment to have loading parking only, because that would serve for the servicing of 20 Foster Street... that would prevent cars from sitting there a long period of time."*

— Councilor Gary Rairdon [40:00]

Rairdon argued a commercial-plates-only loading zone would still let service vehicles reach Wood's property while discouraging long-term parking and preserving room for fire apparatus. Director Dudley clarified that loading zones legally require a commercial plate — excluding an ordinary lawn-care worker's or plumber's personal vehicle, undercutting the idea in practice. The amendment **failed, 0–6**, as did Rairdon's follow-up suggestion of general 2-hour parking in the same stretch (died for lack of a second).

Key Decisions

✓ Original flexible-designation language approved [1:04:02] 5–1, Rairdon the lone dissent.

Action Items

• Director Dudley to meet Carson Wood on-site to finalize exact space placement — Assignee: Engineering & Public Services | Deadline: none set.

New Business (continued)

Order 2026-02 — Rifle Suppressors — Police Department (First Reading) [1:04:27]

Discussion Summary

$24,405.50 for 50 rifle suppressors, paid through the Police Department's federal forfeiture funds. Police Captain Goldberg explained the use: range-training noise reduction/officer hearing protection, and reduced noise impact on the neighborhood near the open-air range if ever deployed on the street.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed first reading, unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-03 — Wastewater Division CCTV Software Subscription (First Reading)

[1:06:17]

Discussion Summary

$8,035 annual software subscription (Industrial Technology Group, LLC dba PipeTech) for the Wastewater Division's closed-circuit-television inspection system; amends the FY 2025-2026 vendor list to add this vendor.

Key Decisions

✓ **Passed first reading, unanimous roll call, 6–0.**

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-04 — Replacement Utility Tractor & Rotary Broom (First Reading)

[1:07:36]

Discussion Summary

$33,160.36 for a John Deere 2025R compact utility tractor and quick-hitch rotary broom (Hall Implement Co., sole-source vendor for John Deere equipment continuity), replacing a 2008 tractor that public services technicians stretched from a 12-year to a 17-year service life.

Key Decisions

✓ **Passed first reading, unanimous roll call, 6–0.**

Action Items

None.

Closing & Executive Session

Public Comment (Second), Referrals & Executive Session [1:09:00]

Discussion Summary

No further public comment; no referrals. Council voted to enter executive session under 1 M.R.S. §405(6)(E) to discuss pending or contemplated litigation, with the Mayor, City Administrator, City Clerk, Director of Planning & Code Enforcement, Director and Deputy Director of Economic & Community Development, and legal counsel invited to attend; the transcript ends there.

Key Decisions

✓ **Motion to enter executive session approved by unanimous roll call, 6–0.**

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names against the official city council roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the presiding officer) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

Produced by Westbrook Currents — westbrookcurrents.com